

ALCHEMY AOE ALLIANCE

TYPE:
HANDBOOK
(HDBK)



PROJECT:
N/A

HDBK--L005

REVISION: R1

Handbook, Alchemy League Season 5

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1 - Referenced Documents

Table 1 below is a list of all specifications that are components to this one. Each of its entries were designed as an interchangeable part, to be used in context for this specification, or others like it:

Specification Number	Nomenclature
<u>MTHD-001</u>	Prize Distribution, Round Robin
<u>MTHD-002</u>	Calculation, Tournament Elo
<u>MTHD-003</u>	Elo Correction, Handicap
<u>MTHD-004</u>	Discipline, Pa2 Round Robin
<u>PSRM-SPC-1</u>	Custom Space Maps, ALS5

Table 1: Bill of Materials

If any part of any documents listed in Table 1 conflict with this specification, then this specification shall assume priority.

2 - Background

The *Alchemy Alliance (ALAL)* is a free and non-profit organization of random map scripters, tournament hosts, content creators, and skilled players dedicated to the advancement of custom random maps in Age of Empires II: Definitive Edition. As the nucleus of the *Alchemy AOE Community*, the *ALAL* publishes quality standards for custom random maps, and curates the finished products to be featured into thematic competitions where adventuresome players may exhibit creative strategies for maximum entertainment value.



3 - Overview

This handbook describes Alchemy League Season 5, an Age of Empires II 1v1 Round Robin competition hosted by the *Alchemy Alliance* in the first Quarter of 2025. This season boasts the following features, summarized in reference below:

- Participants will generally not face an opponent 300 elo higher than they are without handicap.
- Cutting-edge tournament elo calculation from online match history, based on weighted average and refactored to account for win rate.
- Handicap used sparingly to include extremities of bell curve, so that no player will be turned away based on skill.
- Unique bracketing structure & prize distribution.
- Standard Victory Condition on a Custom Map Pool.

4 - Tournament Host

Direct questions/correspondence to TechChariot on discord.

5 - Prize Money

The Alchemy AOE Community places no emphasis on monetary gain, but would still like to offer prizes to attract talent and boost excitement in the League.



5.A - Total Prizes

The rewards offered by this season of Alchemy League are presented in Table 5.A:

Recipients	Challenge	Amount [USD]
Winning Players	Sprint 1	\$80
Winning Players	Sprint 2	\$160
Total		\$240

Table 5.A: Breakdown of Prizes for this Season of Alchemy League

5.B - Distribution

Winning player earnings distributed per MTHD-001, allowing for compensation of the top eight Round Robin scores, with skill bias exponent of 1.25.

5.C - Disbursement

Players eligible for prize winnings shall provide a *PayPal* address –to which money may be exported from the United States of America— within one week of the *end* of the season.

5.D - Transaction Fees

Banking transaction fees to the address provided for §5.C are covered by the tournament.



6 - Timeline

Table 6 below defines important milestones for this season of Alchemy League:

Start Date (YY-MM-DD)	End Date (YY-MM-DD)	Milestone(s):
24-12-15	25-01-05	Handbook Released, Registrations Open
25-01-08	25-01-21	Round 1 (Sprint 1)
25-01-15	25-01-28	Round 2 (Sprint 1)
25-01-22	25-02-04	Round 3 (Sprint 1)
25-01-29	25-02-11	Round 4 (Sprint 1)
25-02-12	25-02-18	Break, Calculate Winnings
25-02-19	25-03-04	Round 5 (Sprint 2)
25-02-26	25-03-11	Round 6 (Sprint 2)
25-03-05	25-03-18	Round 7 (Sprint 2)
25-03-12	25-03-25	Round 8 (Sprint 2)
25-03-26	25-04-01	End, Calculate Winnings

Table 6: Timeline, Alchemy League, This Season

7 - Bracketing Structure

Alchemy League matches players according to a custom neighbor Swiss-type system not available anywhere else.

7.A - Eligibility to Register

Participants shall have 100 1v1 games minimum and win rate between 15% and 85% totaled across all accounts. It is not possible to play in Sprint 2 without first playing in Sprint 1.



7.B - Tournament Elo

Calculated from the most recent 100 1v1 games, linearly weighted per MTHD-002. The computer program that calculates tournament elo shall:

1. Reference internet APIs to garner all alternate or “smurf” accounts corresponding to the same player, derived through IP address, Steam account sharing, and other methods.
2. Reference internet APIs to harvest all relevant match history corresponding to each of these accounts gathered in the previous step.
3. Perform a tolerance sweep on win rate and elo fluctuation over history to estimate a range of possible tournament elos for each participant, with 100% confidence interval.
4. Take tournament elo as the $\frac{3}{4}$ point going from minimum to maximum.

7.C - Number of Divisions

All players are competing for the same total prize pool.

7.D - Neighborly Matchmaking

Participants shall be listed from highest to lowest tournament elo, and matched against 4 “nearby” opponents, such that each player has the same number of matches, regardless of seed number. In this manner, it is impossible to be “bottom” or “top” of division without also being highest or lowest seed in the entire tournament.

7.E - Handicap Correction

Pending skill distribution, it may be impossible to guarantee worthy opponents without using handicap. For each matched set of players, 100 shall be added to the lower of two elos and then MTHD-003 applied to determine corrective handicap. For reference, the result of this process varies depending on skill level, but typically 5% is awarded for every 200 to 300 in tournament elo gap.

8 - League Format

Alchemy League consists of a Round Robin only – no elimination.

8.A - Play Frequency

Each participant shall complete one set per round, which is a two-week period. Note that the schedule is arranged such that the next round starts one week into the previous round. No exceptions or extensions will be granted.

8.B - Set Size

Each set in the Round-Robin is “Play-All-Two”.

8.C - Selecting Maps

The first of two games will be on the “Map of the Round” (see §11.B). Then, players take turns banning three maps each (for a total of six). The map for the second game is selected randomly from the remainder. In this way, no map may be repeated within the same set. Draft link provided in Alchemy server.

8.D - Round Wild

Although most league players will play one match per Round as described in §8.A, it cannot be guaranteed for everyone. An extra round, known as “Round Wild” is allocated for any matches that are left over. The unique features are as follows:

- There is only one “Round Wild” per sprint. It begins and ends with its corresponding Sprint, and the matched players may play at *any time* during that period.
- Assignment of any set of matched players to “Round Wild” is random.
- There is no “Map of the Round” (see §11.B) for “Round Wild”. Instead, both players pick a home map.



8.E - Selecting Civilizations

Civilization Draft consists of five administrative bans, followed by 2 bans each, then 3 picks each, then one snipe each (hidden and parallel), and ends with a pick each. Draft link as follows: <https://aoe2cm.net/preset/YdEkP>.

9 - General Rules

The following general rules apply for this season of Alchemy League:

9.A - Going First

For the purposes of hosting drafts and lobbies, applying bans, etc., when applicable – the HIGHER SEED “goes first” unless otherwise specified.

9.B - Restarts

Restarts are allowed only if a map is bugged from at least one of the following being true.

- Resources are missing, inaccessible, or at least 50% of their surface area is blocked by terrain or another resource.
- Starting player-controlled units are missing or trapped by terrain or resources.

Note: Alchemy League maps are held to higher quality standards than most other AOE2 competitions to mitigate/eliminate the risk of needing restarts.

9.C - Wrong Civ Picked

If a player accidentally selects a forbidden civilization after the game is launched (thus having seen the opponent’s civilization), then the game is restarted with that opponent selecting a civilization for the mistaken player from their available draft.



9.D - Cheating

Cheating is forbidden. The following are considered cheating:

- Bug exploits.
- Failure to disclose all relevant alternate/“smurf” accounts during registration, thereby attempting to mislead the tournament elo calculation.

9.E - Creative Strategies

Laming/Tower Rushes/Town Center Drops are all 100% allowed. Creative strategies are important to the success of the League.

9.F - Nomad Unit Entrapment

Trapping an enemy unit against a forest or another resource using quick-walling before minute 5 is forbidden on nomad maps.



10 - Lobby Settings

Table 10, shown below, summarizes the lobby settings required in every game played for the League:

Setting	Requirement
Data Mod	Default
Game Mode	Random Map
Map Style	Custom
Location	[A Map From The Pool]
Map Size	Tiny (2 Player)
AI Difficulty	Standard
Resources	Standard
Population	200
Game Speed	Normal
Reveal Map	Normal
Starting Age	Standard
Ending Age	Standard
Treaty Length	<None>
Victory	Standard
Lock Teams?	Yes
Team Together?	Yes
Team Positions?	No
Shared Exploration?	No
Lock Speed?	Yes
Allow Cheats?	No
Turbo Mode?	No
Full Tech Tree?	No
Empire Wars Mode?	No
Sudden Death Mode?	No
Regicide Mode?	No
Record Game?	Yes
Antiquity Mode?	Yes

Table 10: Lobby Settings for All League Games



Note from Table 10 that the new “Antiquity Mode” is *enabled*, allowing new options from the latest game patch. Figure 10 demonstrates:

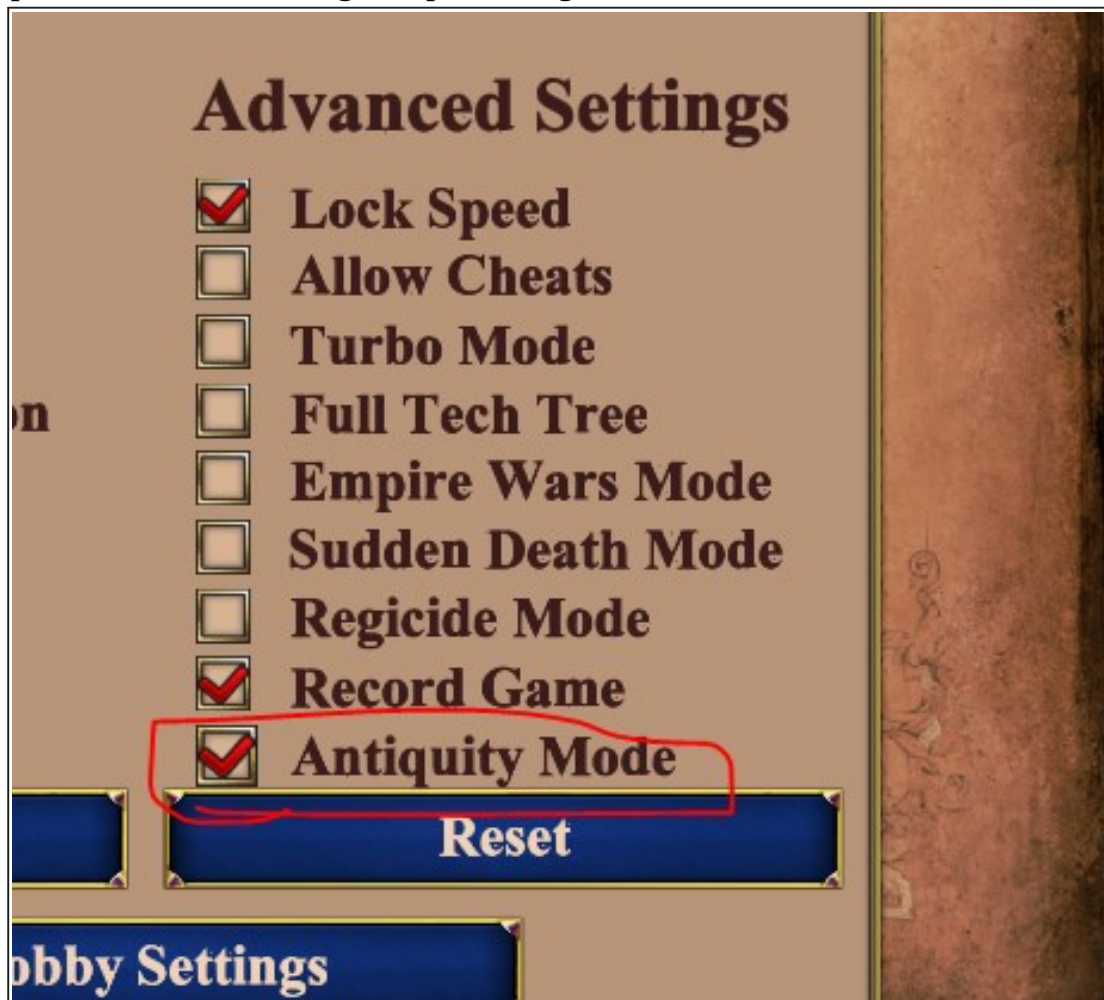


Figure 10: Enabling New Antiquity Mode

11 - Custom Map Pool

Alchemy League is designed to give community members an opportunity to exhibit creative strategies on a custom map pool with unusual victory conditions.

11.A - Download Source

To protect creator intellectual property rights, the Alchemy AOE Community does not upload competition resources to the in-game mod center. A collection of random maps satisfying the requirements of PSRM-SPC-1 shall be downloaded by participants from the following location: [https://github.com/Alchemy-AOE-Community/CHEM-Random-Map-Scripts/tree/Space Maps/Space Maps](https://github.com/Alchemy-AOE-Community/CHEM-Random-Map-Scripts/tree/Space%20Maps/Space%20Maps).

The recommended procedure to programmatically download all of the maps is described here: [https://github.com/Alchemy-AOE-Community/CHEM-Random-Map-Scripts/blob/ About /SETUP ENJOYER.md](https://github.com/Alchemy-AOE-Community/CHEM-Random-Map-Scripts/blob/About%20SETUP%20ENJOYER.md), but it is not required.

The Alchemy AOE Community server is webhook-configured to notify players of any changes to the random map Github repository. Players are responsible for making sure they are using the latest versions. In the case of a desync, it is likely that they are running different versions of the map, and whoever downloaded first should delete their copy to allow lobby transfer from the other player.

11.B - “Map of the Round”

For each round, the tournament host will declare a map from the pool to be “Map of the Round”. A map cannot be “Map of the Round” twice in the same season of the league.



12 - Recording Availability

After playing in each round, recordings proving the outcome shall be uploaded to the appropriate channel in the Alchemy AOE Server before the start of the next round. Although such an upload is ultimately the responsibility of whoever won the set, we would appreciate not being able to predict the winner based on who posted the results.

The following information shall also be included:

- Round Number
- @Player names
- Match Result (Use spoiler tag, sandwich between players)
- Names of maps that were played
- Game Recording Files

A spoiler tag may be attached through use of two vertical bars at the start and end of the message:

|| this is a spoiler message ||

For example, if TechChariot were wiped out by BPDrej in Round 4, then the results could be posted by either player as follows:

Round 4 @TechChariot || 0 - 2 || @BPDrej – Map1, Map2

TechChariot_vs_BPDrej_G1.aoe2record

TechChariot_vs_BPDrej_G2.aoe2record



13 - Performance Tracking

Participants give consent for their performance in Alchemy League to be published as a subject of intense curiosity, particularly among competitors.

14 - Accessibility

It is important for all League participants to be able to find and communicate with each other. Registration will only be processed for persons in the Alchemy AOE Community Discord Server:

<https://discord.gg/h9DvzHBNPr>

15 - Code of Conduct

15.A - Applicability

Alchemy AOE Server Rules apply to all activities related to Alchemy League, including direct messaging and in-game chat.

15.B - Off-Boarding

Any player may withdraw from the league *between* sprints without detriment to the league or their eligibility to register for future Alchemy-AOE events.

15.C - Discipline

If any player fails to meet the commitments of this handbook, then the tournament administrator shall respond according to MTHD-004.



16 - Cosmopolitan Alchemy

The Alchemy AOE Community does not exclude people on the basis of protected class or unpopular beliefs/associations, and our events are designed to unify the Age of Empires II community around love of the game. Anyone is welcome to sign up for our events, as long as they:

- Make a credible pledge to meet the requirements of this handbook.
- Provide an honest estimation of their skill, so that we can be confident in our ability to find them worthy opponents.

17 - Registration

Relevant links provided below:

17.A - Sign Up

<https://forms.gle/2i68xBCrBmkV4cnN7>

17.B - View Signups

<https://docs.google.com/spreadsheets/d/1lqWmuXAeawQTB3udY8zNh6HMNW-6zkEj3DlG2WWBTAs/edit?resourcekey=&gid=1878940162#gid=1878940162>



Signatures:

TechChariot

2024-11-10

Prepared

Date (YYYY-MM-DD)

CookiePirate

2024-12-14

Checked

Date (YYYY-MM-DD)

Honeybadger

2024-12-15

Approved

Date (YYYY-MM-DD)

Revision History:

Revision	Description	Change Document	Date (YYYY-MM-DD)
X1	Advanced Release for Community Review/Feedback	N/A	2024/11/10
OI	----- ORIGINAL ISSUE -----	N/A	2024/12/15
R1	Section 6, Table Title: Revised FROM “ <i>Alchemy League Season 3 Timeline</i> ” TO “ <i>Timeline, Alchemy League, This Season</i> ” Table 10, Row 3 column 2 Revised FROM “Standard” TO “Custom”.	N/A	2025/02/21

